



LCD MONITORS

LCD monitor prices have dipped in the past few months, and now even budget home users can afford one. Apart from the cost of the LCD, there has been remarkable improvement in the quality of colour reproduction. Manufacturers are introducing screens with lower response times, wide-screen displays, anti-glare coatings, etc. However, choosing an LCD over a CRT monitor must be done after understanding the advantages of each.

Questions To Ask The Dealer

What is the native resolution?

LCD screens, unlike CRT monitors, have a fixed maximum resolution called the native resolution, which is set by the manufacturer. This resolution will vary depending on screen type (such as SVGA, XGA, WXGA etc) and screen size (12 inch, 15 inch etc).

Does the LCD monitor support wall-mounting?

You can mount an LCD on a wall using certain wall mount patterns and brack-

ets that are compliant with the VESA mounting standards. Enquire if the LCD you are buying has this feature or if you need to spend extra money to get it done.

Can I connect a VCD/DVD directly to my LCD?

Some LCDs have an S-Video connector, which allows you to connect VCD/DVD players directly to your screen.

Can I use the LCD on both Mac and PC systems?

There are some LCDs that support both Mac and PC systems.

Does the manufacturer support the product with warranty and service centres?

Make sure that the manufacturer supports their product with a good warranty period, and also check for service centres close to your home.

Interesting Facts

Not many of us are aware of dead pixel phenomenon in liquid crystal displays. A dead pixel is a pixel on an LCD screen that doesn't light up when it should be active and displaying some colour.

Dead pixels are normally manufacturing defects, and usually go unnoticed.

Usage Tips

❑ Do not keep an LCD monitor On when the system is idle—this will reduce its life.

❑ An LCD screen is made up of fine crystal sheets, and you may notice a change



in colour as soon as you touch it. Use non-static cloth or cotton cloth to clean your LCD screen. Protect the LCD from any kind of jerks, because any damage of the liquid crystal alignment is permanent.

❑ Some LCDs have memory card readers using which you can run movies or clips or see photos without having to start your PC.

❑ If open windows do not fit properly on the screen, you can use the auto resolution set button—which is available on most LCDs—to automatically resize the screen to fit within the LCD.

The Future

Usage of LCD is gaining popularity—LCD TV entered the Indian market some time ago and is now making its presence felt with 17- and 21-inch screens. There is still a long way to go for them to enter every household. Just like the LCD monitor, LCD TVs are expensive to begin with. These new sets can be interfaced with a PC, VCD/DVD player etc. and also sport memory card slots. Before it can challenge plasma TVs, LCD technology is yet to overcome poor viewing angles! ■

Points To Ponder

Will LCD monitor suit all PC users?

The technology involved in CRT is different from LCD; each has its own advantages. The LCD immediately impresses an onlooker or buyer for its sleek 'lifestyle-like' look, power consumption and the soothing effect it lends to the eyes of a user. Therefore, LCD suits users who are into documentation, programming, and other non-moving graphics-intensive work. CRT is a better option for gamers and frequent movie goers since LCDs do not respond fast enough when displaying moving graphics.

What are the important parameters to consider when buying a LCD?

Contrast ratio is the measure of light intensity between the brightest white and darkest

black; it is simply an indication of the colour representation of LCD. A contrast ratio of 400:1 and above is a good choice.

Luminance is an indicator of how bright a surface—here, the LCD Screen—will appear when looking at it from a particular angle. For a PC, an LCD screen with a luminance factor between 320 cd/m² and 400cd/m² is ideal.

Response times give us an idea of how fast an LCD can respond to fast-moving images. An LCD with a high response time results in the streaking effect, which is, basically, slight blurring of the image. To avoid this, look for low response times. The recommended response time for gaming and movies is 10 milliseconds.